

Fast-Read Summary

Influencing User Decisions: Dilemmas in Designing Online Interfaces — Simon, Schraffenberger & Gellert, NordiCHI Adjunct 2024

Note: this is a discussion/position paper, not an empirical study — so there is no traditional Methodology/Results section. The summary below is adapted accordingly.

Core Concept

Examines why the line between "nudging" (acceptable steering) and "dark patterns / manipulation" (unacceptable steering) is much blurrier than commonly assumed, and illustrates this through three concrete design dilemmas.

Approach

A literature review across philosophy, law, economics, and HCI on how researchers distinguish acceptable from unacceptable steering, followed by three illustrative design dilemmas that well-meaning designers face in practice.

Key Findings

- Existing distinctions rely on three factors: the designer's **intention**, the design's **process/qualities** (transparency, freedom of choice), and the **outcome** (who benefits, welfare impact). These criteria often contradict each other — the same design can be a "nudge" under one criterion and a "dark pattern" under another.
- **Dilemma 1 — "Manipulation for good":** A design can look manipulative (e.g. shaming someone into a healthy choice) yet be well-intentioned and beneficial. Is it acceptable or not?
- **Dilemma 2 — "Who benefits":** What's good for the individual user can conflict with what's good for society (e.g. donation nudges help society but may financially harm the user).
- **Dilemma 3 — "Too much of a good thing":** Transparency and freedom of choice — the supposed hallmarks of ethical design — break down in practice. Too much detail overwhelms users (the "transparency paradox"); too many choices cause decision paralysis.
- Both nudging and dark-pattern research assume users are **irrational and biased**. The authors challenge this assumption and argue for treating users as rational agents deserving of autonomy-supporting design.

Takeaway

There is no clean, reliable rule for separating "good" nudges from "bad" dark patterns — the same tactics (defaults, framing, etc.) can be ethical or exploitative depending on intent, context, and who is judging. The authors call for new design principles built around **user autonomy** rather than patching the existing nudge/dark-pattern distinction.

How This Connects to the Other Two Papers

- **Paper 1** (Bongard-Blanchy et al.) — user side: awareness of dark patterns does not equal resistance to them.
- **Paper 2** (Nie et al.) — tooling side: detection tools and datasets only cover ~50% of known dark pattern types.
- **Paper 3** (Simon et al.) — conceptual/ethical side: even defining what counts as a "dark pattern" versus an acceptable nudge is unresolved.